—in making decisions regarding Iran and in making recommendations to the decision makers and the prime ministers I served.

The first insight came with being exposed to the size and diversity of this huge country. This is a country whose territory is larger than that of all of the countries of western Europe put together. It is a country whose south has an extreme desert climate and whose north has a central European climate. A resident of Tehran could decide on any given day to drive an hour and a half north to ski or to drive an hour and a half south and take a swim in a large lake.

The population of Iran is made up of a huge mix of races and some thirty-six ethnic groups. Looking at a map of the countries bordering Iran on all its sides, one will find that each of them is represented among the various ethnic groups, who over time have become citizens or residents of Iran—from the Slavs on the Caspian coast in the north, to the Kurds and Azeris in the northwest and west, to the Iraqi Arabs in the west and south, and the combination of Baloches, Afghans, Kazakhs, and others in the east and northeast.

The insight I derived from Iran's ethnic structure and size is that only an authoritarian, centralized regime, with powerful and intimidating governing systems, could control a country of this magnitude and a huge population of innumerable races and ethnic groups with no common denominator between them. Moreover, the country's lengthy land borders crossed demographic and ethnic boundaries. These borders had been set in wartime and advanced irredentist aspirations (the aspirations of a cultural or ethnic group to free themselves from the yoke of the political entity under which they are subjects), which led to unrest, instability, and conflict.

During the imperial period, Iran was ruled by various dynasties, each taking power in turn following the destruction of the previous dynasty. The source of Iranian pride can be found in two historical periods: the era of Cyrus the Great, who built a huge empire in the sixth century BCE, and the period of dynasties that ruled from the seventh century until the Khomeini revolution in 1979.

The first Arab conquest of Iran was by the Sassanid kingdom; it began in 637 CE and was completed by 642 CE. Over the years, countless dynasties, some led by Arab rulers and others by Iranian rulers, rose and fell. In the eleventh and twelfth centuries, kingdoms of foreign invaders, such as the Seljuks and the Mongols, ruled. Later, in 1502, the Safavid